The Social Radars
Paul Graham, Founder, Y Combinator

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Jessica:	00:00:00	Carolyn, I'm really excited. It has taken a couple years, but we have Paul Graham back on the show for part two.
Paul:	00:00:09	Part two. Yay. Hey, Paul.
	00:00:11	Here I am.
Jessica:	00:00:12	You'd think it would've been easier for me since I'm your wife, but here we are.
Paul:	00:00:17	The shoemaker's children.
Jessica:	00:00:19	The shoemaker's children, exactly.
Carolynn:	00:00:20	Oh, I say that all the time. I say that all the time about YC, how shoeless, we're always shoeless.
Jessica:	00:00:28	So we had a great conversation the last time and we kind of had left off, we had talked a lot about the history of Y Combinator and we talked a little bit about what you had been up to after Y Combinator, but we didn't get into the growth of Y Combinator and what happened once we had successfully, once it had gotten airborne, what happened? We had eight startups in that very first batch. And we always say we grew it organically, but let's talk about how we grew it.
Paul:	00:01:00	Well, we would just have an application deadline and people would apply and more and more people applied. We never did anything all that consciously to get more people to apply. I mean, we'd announced that there was going to be an application deadline. We would do startup school every year. And I think that probably caused some people to apply. But other than that, we didn't have any sort of conscious effort at marketing. Oh, and I would write essays and people would read the essays and I would have this link interested in starting a startup apply to Y Combinator. So that probably got more people to apply, but there was never any deliberate plan to grow it. We would just get more applications each time.

Carolynn: 00:01:42 How much overlap with Hacker News was there? Because I have to imagine ... Oh, I know for a fact actually that Hacker News was a huge source of applicants.

Paul: 00:01:50 Hacker News, I think I started it in like 2007. So for the first couple years, it wasn't a factor.

Carolynn: 00:01:58 Oh, okay. Yeah.

Jessica: 00:01:59 And in fact, I think when we were first getting going, there was very little press, but then we were in the New York Times and that kind of got us out there.

Paul: 00:02:10 And honestly, the only kind of ... For something like YC, what this is something people don't realize. For something like YC, the only kind of out there that you care about is whether potential applicants know about you. Do 22-year-old programmers know about you? And so if you get an article about you in the New York Times and 22-year-old programmers aren't reading the New York Times, it might seem to you've gotten a lot of publicity, but actually it didn't really help much. I think applicants would talk to one another. I think that was why we grew.

Carolynn: 00:02:46 Did that New York Times article have a theme or a thesis other than just like, check out this new thing? I probably read the article at some point, but I don't remember it. A

Jessica: 00:02:56 Hatchery for startups.

Paul: 00:02:58 Yeah. It was good actually. It described YC as this new phenomenon in the investment world, which at that point it was. So that was actually a pretty useful sort of good historical article.

Jessica: 00:03:12 And kudos to Jenny A. Lee for getting it. No one else did.

Paul: 00:03:16 She could claim to understand early on what was going

Carolynn: 00:03:19 On. You were talking about how that's not the right demographic, because you want 22-year-old programers to know about YC, and we may talk about this a little bit later, but we also had the Tiger Mom problem remember when Adora actually was the first person to explain this, I think, to me in an articulate way. You also need the parents to know about it. So maybe the Times article-

Paul:	00:03:42	Parents could read The New York Times.
Carolynn:	00:03:44	Exactly. That was my point. Yeah.
Paul:	00:03:46	And in fact, early on, this is probably not true so much now because now startups are a more accepted thing to do, but back then in 2005, parents would freak out at the idea that their kids would leave school and not get a job. It wouldn't seem like they were founders. It would merely seem like they were unemployed. And so once YC started to have a big brand, then the founders could say, look, mom, I'm not just working on my loser startup. I got into YC. There's this well-known thing that I got into. I think it helped a lot back in the day.
Jessica:	00:04:21	So what was the secret to our success then, in your opinion?
Paul:	00:04:27	I think we actually helped the startups a lot. And so they would tell one another. If we had sucked, it would be like your friends go to a restaurant, right? And if the food's really good, they tell you, "Hey, you should go to this restaurant. The food's really good." I think people who did YC would tell their friends, "Yeah, we did this thing. It was really good. They helped us a lot. They helped us get investment. Look how they incorporated our startup. They did all this stuff for us." I think it was simply that it helped them a lot and they would tell their friends and then their friends would do it too. And then, well, that's a recipe for exponential growth because then their friends do it. And then there's more people out there telling people that it helped them.
Jessica:	00:05:09	The alumni were critical, I think, in the growth of YC.
Paul:	00:05:13	Because young programmer types know one another. They went to school together, they hang out together. So word spreads quickly. If you please that group, word spreads quickly.
Jessica:	00:05:26	And back when we weren't space constrained, I mean, we used to have alumni come to the dinners sometimes, drop by, and they'd introduce the new startups to their investors, and it was just this really great community.
Paul:	00:05:40	Yeah. And sometimes become their customers.
Jessica:	00:05:43	Along the way, I mean, there were so many ups. I mean, I wouldn't say there were dramatic ups and downs, but there were some crazy stories. And Carolyn and I keep- There were

Paul:	00:05:52	Some pretty dramatic ups and downs, actually. We have forgotten. But I can remember feeling at the end of the day, Jesus, you couldn't make this shit up. And I remember also feeling like this was not an unfamiliar thing. There was always disasters. Stuff was always breaking. Just hacker news all the time. You forget how many times did I have to run off and run to my office and deal with some disaster happening to hacker news, right? That alone- I
Jessica:	00:06:26	Hated hacker news, I have to say. Me too.
Paul:	00:06:29	It was such an unbelievable source of stress. In retrospect, I think maybe that was a mistake. Maybe I shouldn't have done that because- Really? It really was more than half of the total stress of running YC.
Carolynn:	00:06:43	Oh.
Paul:	00:06:44	Oh yeah.
Carolynn:	00:06:45	Well, wait. So do you mean technical dramatic things or community-based dramatic things? Both. Or both? Both.
Paul:	00:06:53	Okay.
Carolynn:	00:06:53	Both. Yeah. Yeah. The community, yes. That actually-
Paul:	00:06:57	Servers running out of file space, denial of service attacks, people getting into terrible fights on the site. I mean, in retrospect, that was like a startup in itself. It was like I was running a startup at the same time as doing YC.
Jessica:	00:07:15	Do you think Twitter impacted our growth?
Paul:	00:07:19	Maybe.
Jessica:	00:07:20	When did that come around? 2007?
Paul:	00:07:23	Something like that. Yeah. I think it probably did a bit. Yeah. People probably ... Because early on, especially all the users, the users have gone through phases. In the beginning, it was like computer nerds. And then it was SJWs and now it's like Trump supporters or bots pretending to be Trump supporters. They're hard to tell apart. And so that first phase, we forget now, but that first phase, it was pretty technical.

Jessica:	00:07:49	Who were some of your favorite speakers? And I asked that because I remember the Twitter founders, all of them, Ev Williams, Jack Dorsey and Biz Stone used to come to our dinners to be guest speakers. And I used to love when they came. Who do you remember as some of your favorite speakers?
Paul:	00:08:07	Zach actually was a pretty good speaker because he was so young. He was so young when he started Facebook. He was probably still at that point, even though he was now famous, he was probably still younger than some of the founders in the batch. So they could really relate to him. I could sort of hear them all becoming more ambitious as they thought, okay, here's this guy. He's super famous and very rich, but he doesn't seem like he's a different species of animal from me. Why can't I do what he did? You can sort of hear him all. And he was pretty candid. Back in those early days. I mean, I hope this is still mostly true, but back in the early days, the speakers used to be completely candid. Nobody worried much about whether something they said would get out, because even if it did get out, this was before cancel knobs were invented, right?
	00:09:03	What was going to happen?
Carolynn:	00:09:05	What was the first year? Do you guys remember the first time he came? The first time that came? Yeah.
Paul:	00:09:12	Well, it was in California, obviously. It was pretty early on. It must
Jessica:	00:09:17	Have been like 2007.
Paul:	00:09:19	Yeah, seven or eight, I would think.
Jessica:	00:09:22	Yeah, pretty early. I remember we met him at a restaurant in Palo Alto. Do you remember that, Paul?
Paul:	00:09:29	Well, this was before he had learned to imitate a normal person, right? Early Zuck. I mean, I don't know if Zuck publicly describes himself as being an aspie, but he was doing a good imitation of it at any rate. And so he had this weird thing where if he didn't have anything to say, he wouldn't fill the gap with passing- Small talk. Yeah. Yeah. He had no concept of small talk. If there wasn't anything he felt like saying at the moment, he would just go like this. And it was surprisingly disconcerting. I didn't realize how important small talk was until I met the lack of it, but he would just stare at you. If there wasn't anything, he's like, "I don't have any words I want to say. Why should I say words?" Didn't

Jessica:	00:10:21	Ron set it up?
Paul:	00:10:23	Well, Ron in fact warned me about this specifically. He said, "All right, you're going to meet Mark. Now I warn you, there's going to be some big gaps in the conversation." When he said that, I didn't realize what he meant, but then I felt it.
Carolynn:	00:10:39	I see a good Ron imitation also. I just want to compliment you because it's kind of just like him.
Jessica:	00:10:43	Yeah.
Paul:	00:10:44	I've got a lot of practice imitating Ron.
Jessica:	00:10:48	Zuck used to come and he would speak at our startup school events and that drew a lot of people. He was a big draw. The startup
Paul:	00:10:56	World back then, people didn't care so much. Outsiders didn't care so much about the startup world. This was before ... Even now, we think if something big happens in the startup world, it's a news story. But why should it be? If something big happens in the hospitality industry or the mining industry or like the advertising industry, it's not automatically some kind of big story for everybody. It's only interesting to people who are in that industry, right? The trade press might write about it. And it was so weird to me when startups became something that the general public would be interested in. I mean, I understand why they're interested in the private lives of movie stars. Why would they be interested in the private lives of startup founders? But they started to be, and they still are. It's so weird. But back then, this was before they cared.
	00:11:46	This was before that phenomenon had started. And so we were just like our own little people working in the ... We were the computer club.
Jessica:	00:11:53	It was such happy times. And actually it was still happy when they did start taking notice, but it became very unhappy once, I don't know when the turning point was. Well, there was
Paul:	00:12:05	Two things that happened, right? There was when the press started taking notice of Silicon Valley, and then almost at the same time, wokeness started in around 2012. And then so they would be busting YC. You'd have not YC, but just everybody in Silicon Valley, you felt like there was this mob, this incipient mob ready to form at any moment, right? If you said or did the wrong

thing, they would come and bust you and hound you. So that wasn't fun. That combination of being visible plus wokeness.

Jessica: 00:12:41 I feel like if I look back on my history of YC, the thing that, not Hacker News, but what gave me the most heartburn in life was all the negative press around us and all the Twitter mobs that were based on lies.

Paul: 00:12:57 Yeah. Yeah. We're all

Jessica: 00:13:00 Nervous

Paul: 00:13:01 Laughter. Peter Thiel secretly running the company. Oh my

Jessica: 00:13:04 Gosh. Wait. Oh, I think we have to tell that story, Peter Thiel's story. Sure. So Peter Thiel, oh my God, what year was this? What year was this? It was after Sam took over.

Paul: 00:13:17 But it was soon after Sam took over.

Jessica: 00:13:19 Yes, it was. He was good friends with

Paul: 00:13:22 Yourself. So in 2015 or something.

Jessica: 00:13:24 2015. And didn't he say, Hey, Peter, will you be a part-time partner? I put it in quotes because he did one office hours or

Paul: 00:13:34 Something. Okay. No, I'll tell you the whole story. Okay. So we had this thing, you probably still have something like it. We had this thing that I named mostly for alliterative purposes, part-time partners, which is people who weren't YC partners, but would come in and like for no money, they had no duties. They got paid nothing. They weren't really supposed to do anything, right? But experts in some aspect of the startup world would come in and they would do office hours with the startups even though they weren't actual partners. And we called these people part-time partners and we had them listed on the website. And so Peter Thiel at one point was a part-time partner and I got into a fight on Twitter with somebody who I don't want to name because he's since apologized. I don't want to give him grief. But in the process of this fight, he picked up as if to throw at me like a brick, the fact that Peter Thiel was a part-time partner.

00:14:31 And when were we going to get rid of Peter Thiel? Because Peter Thiel had committed what was in 2015, an unforgivable cancelable sin, which was to be openly Republican. And so there

was this mob formed to try and force YC to fire Peter Thiel. And the story grew to the point where Peter Thiel was supposedly like not ... I mean, part-time partners did nothing.

00:15:02 And the story was that Peter Thiel was like running YC where he was like the head of the chairman of the board or something like that. And honestly, all he was- And my

Carolynn: 00:15:11 Best friends with you, you'd met him once.

Paul: 00:15:14 Right. Yeah. The funny thing was, so there was all this mob telling YC, we had to fire Peter Thiel, right? Well, the funny thing was Peter Teal in the previous year had done four office hours. And so Sam had been planning to fire him anyway, fire in the sense of say, okay, you don't seem to be actually doing anything. Maybe we'll stop calling, stop listing. He was a part-time partner. So Sam had been planning to fire him. And then there was this mob saying that we had to fire him for being a Republican. And so it seemed like it would be a really bad idea. What I told Sam about this was like, you do not want to be the one who sets a precedent in this sense. You do not want to be the company that fires somebody for supporting the wrong one of two political parties.

00:16:06 As much as I dislike Trump, you don't want to fire somebody for that. And so Sam, even though he'd been planning to fire him, now had to not fire him because that would've seemed like giving into the mob.

Carolynn: 00:16:17 Well, and to be clear, I think it was like, "Hey, Peter, come help some startups when you have time." And he literally didn't have time. He probably just didn't have time to do it. So I'm not even willing to say the guy was bad at being a part-time partner. I think he just was busy. So he wasn't coming around. So Sam was going to be like, "Hey, dude, this isn't working out. We're going to take you off the website." That was literally what it was going to be. And then it turned into this whole thing and it was like, YC, you have to fire this guy who's, like I said, practically, I think the narrative was he's practically running YC. Well, please, the guy was too busy to even be around. It was so frustrating. And by the way, and I am happy to stand corrected if I'm wrong about this, but the whole partnership, I remember this day, we were all sitting around that big table in 335 and everyone was like, no, it was emotional because we felt very attacked and it's like no way we're going to take him off the website just because these people are saying we have to.

00:17:15 That's messed up.

Paul: 00:17:17 Or more like the other way around. We're going to keep them on the website because they're telling us we have to take them off. Exactly. Now that we're remembering all what it felt like to have a council mob after us, and that probably happened 20 times, right? That was pretty stressful. The funny thing is wokeness has now decreased so much on Twitter especially, but just in general that people can't imagine the shit we went through like growing YC. The years where we were really growing YC fast was also the exact same years that wokeness was really growing fast. And you know why YC got so much shit? Because we were the only consumer brand in the venture business. There's all these prestigious venture firms, but ordinary people don't know their names. YC takes open applications from essentially job applicants, people who are just graduating from college.

00:18:16 So YC had to have a consumer brand. We had to be known by everybody. We're not just doing series As. And so these people wanted to blame Silicon Valley. And since they were outsiders, they didn't know who the participants were. The only people they knew in Silicon Valley were YC. And so everything, all the problems in the world were Silicon Valley's fault. The only person in Silicon Valley that they knew was me. So all the problems in the world were my fault. I know.

Jessica: 00:18:47 Can you

Paul: 00:18:47 Imagine? So unfair. So you remember how we started talking about this? Was it actually stressful doing YCM thinking, "I bet we're forgetting something." It probably was pretty stressful because I remember feeling really beaten up all the time.

Jessica: 00:19:01 And I think it was more stressful because of all of the tax than the actual startup implosions.

Paul: 00:19:08 Actually doing the job was much less stress than being attacked for doing the job in the press, right? Exactly.

Carolynn: 00:19:15 There was still a lot of stress doing the job too. Yeah,

Paul: 00:19:19 There was a good deal of stress. There was a lot of fighting that we had to do behind the scenes on behalf of the startups because people would maltreat the startups and then you have to go basically ... It's like two kids have a fight and the parents go and talk to each other. If someone tried to maltreat the startups, we would have to go and talk to their investors and say, "Come on, this isn't right. They have to back off."

Jessica: 00:19:42 Paul did that all the time. Do you remember the ad grocks? Do you remember them?

Paul: 00:19:46 Well, Antonio wrote a book about this. "This story will be preserved because yeah, they weren't a super, super successful startup. "This is one of the weird things about YC. People imagine because the famous successful startups like Airbnb and DoorDash and Coinbase are what become known later, they imagine that during the batch, we were spending all our time talking to Airbnb and DoorDash and Coinbase and no, actually Airbnb was probably in a batch of like 25 startups and they got one 25th of the time. At any given time, I was talking to some startup nobody's ever heard of now. And so the amount of trouble caused by startups is not remotely in proportion to how big they end up being. In fact, it's probably an inverse proportion. So you spend basically YC means you spend all of your time dealing with these really naughty problems like K-N-O-T-T-Y, naughty, not naughty, naughty.

00:20:46 You spend all your time dealing with these contorted, miserable problems for companies that are never going to amount to much anyway, but it's the nature of the business.

Jessica: 00:20:56 I want to flip this conversation because I'm feeling very negative. I want to talk about so many of the positive things that happened. Do you remember giving any advice you gave to some of our most successful startups that really helped them? Do you remember? Oh,

Paul: 00:21:11 Airbnb. Airbnb, absolutely. They would've died without YC. I mean, they were dead when they showed up, though we didn't know it. But telling them to focus on New York, just focus on that one initial market because you need to get this ball rolling. That ended up making all the difference for the company. And so that's the best case scenario when you can tell a startup something that makes them take off and then they become huge. That's the dream situation. That's not how it usually worked. Usually you would tell people something and they would ignore you and then they would fail. That was the usual situation. That was the median case.

Jessica: 00:21:58 What was that famous quote that you gave to some startup you're like, thank God we fund 50 startups because you're driving into off a cliff right

Paul: 00:22:08 Now. If you want to drive off a cliff, that's fine with me. I think they're actually doing pretty well

Jessica:	00:22:13	Still. Who'd you say that to?
Paul:	00:22:15	What was the company called? The founder's name was Brandon and then I think he left. Oh,
Jessica:	00:22:20	Sift Science? No.
Paul:	00:22:22	Yeah, I think it was Sift.
Jessica:	00:22:24	Really?
Paul:	00:22:24	I think they're quite successful.
Jessica:	00:22:28	I didn't know you said that to them. Oh
Paul:	00:22:32	Gosh.That story was printed in a book, that book, The Launchpad.
Jessica:	00:22:36	Yes.
Paul:	00:22:37	So that will be preserved too.
Jessica:	00:22:39	Carolyn, were there any moments ... This is a very naughty N-A-U-G-H-T-Y question. Were there any emails that happened that Paul sent that you were like, "Oh geez. Oh
Carolynn:	00:22:53	Gosh." Well, probably, but no. Actually, I don't think I thought that like, "Oh, this is going to get us into legal trouble kind of emails."
Paul:	00:23:04	No, I never would say things that we got into
Jessica:	00:23:06	Legal. Legal troubles, make people mad. Yeah. Just like, "Oh, that's really going to piss them
Carolynn:	00:23:11	Out. " I'm sure that I was like, "This is exactly the harsh truth that this founder needs to hear." I don't think I ever had the reaction like, "Oh, that's going to go over poorly."
Paul:	00:23:20	Okay, that's good.
Carolynn:	00:23:21	I think people sometimes just need sort of the unvarnished truth from someone who's like, "Look, this is what you need to hear."
Paul:	00:23:27	I wanted them all to succeed. I wasn't going to be shooting them down.

Jessica:	00:23:31	Paul, no one worked harder than you, I swear, at helping startups who are failing. You would not give up on them. Other people would be like, "Whoa, just let that one go. " And Paul would be like, "No, I'm going to help them with a new idea." Or you would just work so hard.
Paul:	00:23:49	This time will be different.
Jessica:	00:23:51	When did you start taking Office Hours? Remember when you built the software that allowed startups to book office hours? The booker? The booker. You built that, right?
Paul:	00:24:02	I wrote that every bit of our software. Don't you realize up till the point where I retired, I wrote every bit of our software except the JavaScript that did the up and down buttons on Hacker News, which PB wrote because I had a no JavaScript. I wrote everything. If we had software, I wrote it. And I wrote every word on our website.
Jessica:	00:24:25	Yeah. Yeah. Our website was awesome. I love our research.
Paul:	00:24:29	It's why my hair's white now.
Carolynn:	00:24:30	One of my memories of that era is how you would always ... Well, you would frequently help startups with your name. And I think we might've talked about this.
Paul:	00:24:39	I still do that.
Carolynn:	00:24:40	No, no, no. I know. So my question for you is, do you have a name you're particularly proud of where you're like, "Why don't you call yourselves this? " And they're like,
Paul:	00:24:49	"Amazing." Imjix. I- M-G-I-X, five letters.
Jessica:	00:24:56	Carolyn has no idea who Mjix is.
Carolynn:	00:24:58	No, I do. I remember the name. What batch is it though?
Paul:	00:25:01	Oh God, I don't remember batches. Find, P-H-I-N-D.
Carolynn:	00:25:05	Oh, I remember that one.
Jessica:	00:25:07	I feel like if I had a dollar for every time you were at instant domain search with founders during an office hours, you have

Paul:	00:25:14	A lot of money. Right on your kitchen counter. Oh my goodness. Because you need them to stand around and look over your shoulder. So I'd do it right on the island in the kitchen. So many names. So many startups names have been found at that one corner of the island.
Jessica:	00:25:27	So you're kind of famous for blowing up people's ideas, like taking their idea- Growing
Paul:	00:25:33	Up in the good
Jessica:	00:25:34	Sense. In the good sense. In the good sense. Making them, here's how you can be the next Google. And you used to do this and some startups would take your advice, some others wouldn't. Can you remember an instance of that? Because you'd come home and you'd be like, "Oh wow, if you had been there, you wouldn't believe the idea we cooked up." Yeah. It's going to be the next Google.
Paul:	00:25:56	I can't remember specific instances because I would do it so much. I mean, I would do it like maybe one third of the office hours I did. We would figure out how to make an idea much bigger. Yeah,
Jessica:	00:26:10	It happened all the time and still does happen.
Paul:	00:26:14	Yeah. When I do office hours, now I still do that. And I see these startups right in the beginning of the batch sometimes, and so there's a lot of room to expand their idea.
Jessica:	00:26:23	I want to also talk about you were good at working with the startups on their demo day pitches. Tell the listeners about sort of what used to happen before demo day with the founders. I would
Paul:	00:26:37	Write their demo day pitches.
	00:26:41	One of those little secrets. We would do this thing called vertebrae office hours where we would figure out what were the vertebrae of their demo day presentation. Because the thing about demo day is you're up there with 50 or now like 300 other startups. And so the investors are not going to remember anything about your presentation. By the time they get to the end, their brain will be wiped clean. And so you really can only hope that they'll remember about five sentences worth of stuff in the very best case. And so you should decide in advance what those sentences will be. And those are the vertebrae of your

demo day presentation. The rest is just filler, essentially. And so we would try and figure out what are the five sentences that everybody ought to remember about this startup that would cause someone to invest in them.

00:27:28 There are five sentences with the specific purposes. So like, this is going to be a giant market. We are already solving the problem better than anybody else. It's ours to lose. And when we get there, there's network effects. And so that means it's winner takes all. You're already wanting to invest, don't you?

Jessica: 00:27:49 Yeah. Sounds great.

Paul: 00:27:51 That's the thing. Demo day presentations shouldn't be like fast talking marketing speak. They should be almost like logical proofs of why this company is good to invest in. You follow, if you agree with this step and this step and this step, they all follow from one and the other, and the end result is the expected value is really high. That's a good demo day presentation.

Jessica: 00:28:15 But I feel like you did more than just vertebrae. You would spend hours and hours and hours at YC and people would just come

Paul: 00:28:24 In. Well, I would do the vertebrae with them and sit down and think, okay, this is what the core of your presentation should be. And then they would go off and make something that said what I said to say. And then I would sit there and they would practice. Before demo day, they would come to YC and take turns standing there, projecting their slides and talking. And I would sit there in the audience essentially, almost like a playwright saying, "No, no, cut that. " Right? Say that.

Jessica: 00:28:52 If you were like a playwright, you'd be like, no, say this. Don't use that word. Say this. It was so, such specific information. We

Paul: 00:28:59 Went that part down. We were always trying to get people to talk slower.

Jessica: 00:29:04 Oh gosh.

Paul: 00:29:05 Yes. Yeah. See, you remember. I can remember, wasn't there somebody who wrote Talk Slower on their shoes so that when they looked down, it was like talk on one shoe and slower on the other or something like that. I think online, I think there's a recording of me sitting talking to Brian Armstrong about his demo day presentation. I think that might be online on YouTube.

Jessica:	00:29:30	Oh, that's pretty cool. And then I think you'd be like a nervous parent sitting in the green room at demo day the whole time.
Paul:	00:29:40	No, no, no. I didn't sit in the green room. I was only in the green room during the breaks. When they were presenting, I would be out there taking notes and I would be wondering, will they get this part right? Because I knew what was coming in all of their presentations. I mean, there may be a few who didn't come into practice at Y I see. And so I wouldn't know what they were going to say, but 90% of the time I knew what they were going to say and I was hoping, will they get this line right? Will they
Carolynn:	00:30:08	Deliver- Will it land?
Paul:	00:30:10	Yeah. Will it land? And so I'd be sitting there over on the side, watching every presentation, seeing if it landed. There was a lot of stuff in retrospect. Yeah. In addition to being attacked constantly in the press, there was all this actual stuff we were doing.
Jessica:	00:30:26	I used to say, and I've believed this, that even if your startup failed, I truly believe that anyone who came out of the YC program felt like it was a great experience and valuable for them. And I- Well, you had
Paul:	00:30:41	To learn a lot. Yeah. If you were even awake, you couldn't avoid learning a lot from the experience of trying to build something and get it in front of users and figure out how to make it grow and how to explain it to investors.
Carolynn:	00:30:54	And then we would do a post-batch survey and I remember you saying, "If all they complain about is the food on Tuesday nights, we're doing it right." Yes.
Paul:	00:31:02	We were always happy when they complained about the food because that meant there was nothing more substantial to complain about. So we were delighted. I mean, the food wasn't a deliberate canary in the coal mine, but it ended up effectively serving that purpose. I think the food's better now though.
Carolynn:	00:31:20	Yeah, it's all different now. Do you
Paul:	00:31:21	Remember that time dinner basically consisted of hot orange juice?
Jessica:	00:31:24	I knew you were going to say the chickpeas with the orange juice.

Paul:	00:31:28	Well, someone, at one point we had this cook who was adventurous in a bad way and made this sort of orange flavored chickpea dish. But the founders took out all the solid bits of this stew and all that was left was this sort of hot orange juice with the few.
Jessica:	00:31:44	It was orange chicken. Orange chicken, Carolyn, which seems a little bit more normal. And then the veggie option was the same sauce, orange chickpeas.
Carolynn:	00:31:55	And the chig bees
Jessica:	00:31:57	Were disgusting.
Carolynn:	00:31:58	Oh no. Orange
Jessica:	00:31:59	Juice. I feel like, Paul, you absolutely were like, "We've got something's broken here. We've got to change."
Carolynn:	00:32:07	The complaints about the food are legit this time and we actually need to change something. Yeah. Oh, I mean,
Paul:	00:32:12	The complaints about the food often were legit.
Carolynn:	00:32:14	Oh yeah. Well, the other thing that YC I think still does, but you guys did a lot was inflection point office hours. So not just these vertebrae often, but inflection point office hours. And I'm sure there's some stories from those. I got to sit in on one of them and it was really interesting.
Paul:	00:32:36	Well, Inflection Point was sort of an optimistic name for what was going to happen, right? This is when a startup is currently on a trajectory that will crash into the ground and we're hoping an inflection point is when a line bends in another direction, right? And so this is when the line's going down and we hope it's going to start going up. So inflection point office hours is when a startup was in terrible shape. We would get them together with multiple partners and we'd sit there and figure out how do we save this thing?
Jessica:	00:33:04	But I'm going to interject in terrible shape, but had promising founders.
Carolynn:	00:33:09	Yes. Right.
Paul:	00:33:10	Yes. Because if they didn't seem like they had any hope, should we talk about palliative

Carolynn:	00:33:16	Care? I was just thinking, should we actually
Jessica:	00:33:18	Talk about this? Maybe it's time. Maybe it's okay. Okay. Because it was our thing. The new partners don't use this expression.
Paul:	00:33:25	Yeah. Do you know about this, Carolyn, palliative careman? Of course. Of course. Okay. Okay. So if the startup was doing really badly and it seemed like they had hope, then we would bring them in and we'd say, "All right, come on, let's figure out how to change things to make this startup succeed." If it seemed like they were doomed and they'd be better off just having jobs working for somebody else, we would have this thing we called palliative care mode where we would just be really nice to them. So at least as their startup was dying, they would be cheerful and happy about it.
Carolynn:	00:33:59	So no tough
Jessica:	00:34:00	Love. Just love. Yeah. No tough love.
Carolynn:	00:34:03	Just love.
Paul:	00:34:04	We would do tough love if we thought it might work.
Carolynn:	00:34:07	Right. That's what I'm saying. You wouldn't bother with tough love for the palliative care startups. You just give them gentle care.
Paul:	00:34:14	You'd just be really, really nice to them.
Jessica:	00:34:17	And gentle care.
Paul:	00:34:18	And so we knew. We knew which companies we hoped we could turn around and which ones we thought were doomed and we were just going to be real nice to them.
Jessica:	00:34:28	I love that you brought up Inflection Point office Hours. That was such a fun thing. I'd forgotten about that. That we did. I know. What else, Carolyn? What else do you remember?
Carolynn:	00:34:35	Well, I remember we all went to lunch. We probably had partnered lunch and we came back and we had Inflection Point office hours with Adora. And she probably talked all about ... I mean, I know she already talked about her whole home joy journey when we talked to her. But then there was a second one, and I'm afraid I don't remember the name of that startup, but when the founder walked in, we had a 15-minute

conversation first because you told him he looked like a Roman emperor. I think you told him he looked like Niro. So we had this random tangent where we all talked about Roman emperors. Well,

Paul: 00:35:05 That's not the emperor you want to look like.

Carolynn: 00:35:07 Well, I think that's why it was somewhat controversial and we're all chuckling and the founder was chuckling. Then we're all started Googling Roman emperors. And anyway, I don't even remember the startup or how things turned out.

Paul: 00:35:19 Do you remember the meme that I only like to fund founders who look like Zuck?

Carolynn: 00:35:26 I do remember that meme. I do remember that meme.That

Jessica: 00:35:30 Persisted for years in the press.

Paul: 00:35:33 I wouldn't be surprised if it's still out there. All because we once met this, because now you know me. I see something. If there's something unusual about their face, I notice it and even say something. And so we were once interviewing this guy who looked very much like Zuck, right? And we even funded him too. We did fund him. The company barely ... I don't think they even made it to the end of YC. No, I think-

Jessica: 00:35:58 They had

Paul: 00:35:58 Some co-founder dispute.

Jessica: 00:36:00 Yeah.

Paul: 00:36:01 And so a reporter said ... There was a reporter embedded in the batch, that batch, I think. And he asked, "Can you be fooled by anyone?" Well, and I jokingly self-deprecating, he said, "Apparently I can be fooled by people who look like Zuck." And man, for five years afterwards, I was only funding founders who look like Zuck. It probably set back hairstyles in Silicon Valley by 10 years.

Jessica: 00:36:26 Do you also remember when someone asked you about what advice would you give bringing in these foreign, I forget where they're from, founders over, what advice would you give to them?

Paul:	00:36:39	I said, "Make sure they speak fluent English." Honestly, that's the most important thing you could do.
Jessica:	00:36:47	That persisted for years that you discriminated against anyone with an accent, which the answer to that is come to a demo day. Tell us if we actually discriminate against people with accents. Oh my word. Oh my
Paul:	00:37:01	God. Yeah. It's like the
Jessica:	00:37:02	Tower Bay. Back to the demody thing. Do you remember you used to work with people at Demo Day who had such thick accents that it was hard to understand them? You worked
Paul:	00:37:12	With them like- There was one founder. There was one founder that I eventually got to memorize her speech phonetically like Aba, the group Aba used to do. You know how Aba's original, their early songs sound like they're not native speakers. They don't know the meanings of the words they're saying. That's because they didn't know the meanings of the words they were saying. They were just singing it as sounds. And there was one founder whose accent was so strong that she had to memorize her demo day presentation phonetically.
Jessica:	00:37:44	That's amazing. I want to talk a little bit about Sam Altman too today. Okay.
Paul:	00:37:49	As long as we're talking about famous lies, everyone tells about YC. Let's talk about the lie that we fired Sam. Oh,
Jessica:	00:37:57	We're going to do some myth busting. Well, let's first reminisce about Sam, because Sam's part of our history the whole time. And actually Carolyn wouldn't be sitting there if it weren't for Sam because Carolyn was Sam's lawyer. That's right.
Paul:	00:38:14	That was how we met you. Sam's lawyer, because Sam was the first startup that was so successful. They actually had a lawyer.
Jessica:	00:38:24	That's right. So Sam we had known for years and Sam was always in the picture. Even when he was working on Looped, he would still come to dinner.
Paul:	00:38:34	Yeah, he was always around. He
Jessica:	00:38:35	Was always around and he definitely was our go- to. You need fundraising advice, go talk to Sam.

Paul: 00:38:41 Yeah. He was the best. Even then, I mean, now my God, he's the God of fundraising. But even early on, he was among the best fundraisers in Silicon Valley.

Jessica: 00:38:52 Tell me what your opinion of him was in the very early days in the first batch.

Paul: 00:38:59 Well, Sam, some people that YC has funded, I gradually realized were a big deal. With Sam, it was instant. Sam, in the first minute of talking to him, I can remember thinking. I can remember what I thought at that time. I thought, okay, this must be what Bill Gates was like when he was 19, because Sam was 19 then. And I had always wondered. Bill Gates ended up starting Microsoft when he was 19. What could he have been like? Because I certainly was not in a position to start Microsoft when I was 19. And then I met Sam and I'm like, okay, this is what one of these 19-year-olds is like.

00:39:38 He seemed like he was 40, just like this looked 19. And so even that batch, he was the big dog. He was the one who got Sequoia to invest in him. He was the one who raised serious money already. He sort of acted like he was ... If that had been a high school class, he would've been the class president. That's sort of what it was like, even during the batch. And then after that, he was always around. We'd go and visit Looped or he would be around YC, and then he became available. I think he got bought and he had to go and work for the acquirer for some time, but then he was free. And so Sam being available at the same time I was thinking of retiring, I thought the obvious choice. Get Sam. And I was right about one thing. I thought to myself, Sam gets whatever he wants in life.

00:40:39 If the only way he can succeed is by making Y Combinator succeed, then My Combinator cannot fail. And so it's not like I considered lots of options for who to be president. Sam was obviously it. And I even spent a year convincing him because at first he didn't want to do it. And the mistake that I made, the mistake that I made was that if Y Combinator is the only way Sam can succeed, right? Because he has gotten what he wanted. But what I should have said when I hired him or when I got him to replace me, what I should have said, "By the way, I want you to take over YC. And also you could only do YC. You're not allowed to work on

Carolynn: 00:41:21 Anything else." Well, he might've said no if you had phrased it that way.

Paul:	00:41:25	No, no, I think he would've taken it. I think at that point, because at that point he didn't know what the other things he wanted to work on were. All these other schemes he cooked up were after taking over YC. So at that point it was just like ... And there's lots of room to become giant by taking over YC.
Jessica:	00:41:40	And some of his schemes were YC schemes. Carolyn's familiar with this.
Carolynn:	00:41:46	Yeah.
Paul:	00:41:47	Yes. The basic universal basic income thing or rebuilding cities. There were all these side projects.
Carolynn:	00:41:55	Yeah.
Paul:	00:41:56	Yeah. One of which was OpenAI. OpenAI.
Carolynn:	00:42:00	Right.
Paul:	00:42:01	I know you don't like us mentioning this.
Carolynn:	00:42:04	Oh no, I don't mind that. It makes me sad because really, because my heart's at YC, and I totally get Sam and I totally get why he got distracted by other things he wanted to do. He was young and he had a million ideas and some of them are amazing. AI
Paul:	00:42:25	Is actually a huge deal.
Carolynn:	00:42:26	It's a huge deal. Who are we to sit here as armchair quarterbacking, this piece of it? I'm glad, but I also ... At the time it made me sad. Okay, I'm going to circle back to the shoemaker's children never having shoes. It does always feels that a little bit, but it felt like that a lot at the time because Sam was so distracted by these other things that really, really interested him that it felt like we were like the barefoot child that didn't get very much love. That's how it felt,
Paul:	00:42:57	Honestly. No, no, I know. I know. And the myth out there is that we fired Sam from YC. And really, if Sam had said, okay, this AI thing, I'll get somebody else to do this so I can focus entirely on YC, we would've been psyched. We would've taken that deal. All we wanted was him to pick and didn't pick. He picked OpenAI.
Jessica:	00:43:22	The truth was also he never thought the OpenAI thing would grow to the point where it was. And all of a sudden- You know

Paul: 00:43:30 How you can tell he never knew how big it was going to be, that he started it as a nonprofit. I mean, what a disaster that has been for him. I think there's people out there who think Sam was pulling a fast one by starting it as a nonprofit. My God, his life would've been so much easier if he started as a for- profit company. And it's not like he needed it to be a nonprofit to get the money. Sam was the world's best fundraiser. Sam could easily have raised enough money to do it as a for- profit thing. You know what it was, and this is actually quite revealing. Nobody knew then, because this was like 2015 or something when he started OpenAI. Nobody knew then that it would be worth spending so much on AI. Isn't that interesting? This was before there was anything that you could do with a million GPUs, right?

00:44:22 Now AI is so valuable. It's worth spending a vast amount of money on it, and therefore you have to raise more than you could possibly ever raise as a nonprofit. But the fact that you would even think you could start, you could even do this as a, you could be an AI thing as a nonprofit. It just shows you how small it seemed back then. You could fund it with donations, right? Ridiculous.

Jessica: 00:44:44 So OpenAI was getting bigger than he had imagined. YC was getting a little bit neglected. Press release goes out saying OpenAI is now a for- profit company and Sam's the CEO. And I remember thinking, okay, now we need to just have a heart to heart with Sam. And we had a heart to heart with Sam. We said, "Can't do both. We totally get that you want to work on AI. Do you agree that we need to find a successor?" I remember saying that and he was very fine about it. He said, "I totally agree." And we worked on that and we found Jeff who was a partner

Paul: 00:45:24 At YC. We both like Jeff. Jeff was sort of the obvious choice because Jeff was already a YC partner. He was sort of established and legitimate and serious and he was the obvious person to take over then. But then he only did it for three years. And do you remember how bummed we were when he told us he wanted to quit? We thought, what? You've only been doing it for three years, right? But I guess, I mean, he told me- He retired.

Jessica: 00:45:50 He wanted to retire.

Paul: 00:45:51 Yeah. But then it turned out we could get Gary and we never realized that was even possible.

Jessica: 00:45:59 Right, because he was running initialized.

Paul:	00:46:02	Yeah. Gary had one ... I mean, Jeff couldn't help this, but he had not done YC. And really, I think it's good if the president of YC has done YC, right? So they know what it feels like to be the founders, trying to raise money or get growth or have demo day coming up. So Gary had done YC and was popular with LPs. He was a known quantity to the LPs who trusted him because he made so much money for them and initialized and he was young and energetic and ready to spend too much time working on YC. I think you found a thing he works too hard. So now, I don't know about you guys, but I feel like this is the best I've ever felt about YC. It used to be for 10 years there. There was always some worry in the back of my mind, some nagging worry.
	00:46:58	And now it feels like ... Don't you remember? We had a board meeting and we were like, wait a minute, there didn't seem to be anything wrong. That was so novel. Oh
Jessica:	00:47:09	My God, we have shoes. Yes. We find a lot of
Paul:	00:47:13	Shoes. The shoemaker's children finally got some shoes.
Jessica:	00:47:16	Right. Paul, Carolyn, you probably don't know this, but earlier today, Paul tweeted that he was going on the show and did anyone have any questions for him? Oh my God, how fun. I wonder if I should look at a couple. What do you guys think? Definitely.
Paul:	00:47:32	Can't hurt. We know that Twitter reply threads are full of fabulously valuable insights.
Jessica:	00:47:37	Maybe there's some good questions in there. Okay. Well, there are 149 responses. Whoa. So I'm going to just read a couple, Paul, and you can sort of choose. I'll read. Okay. Can you talk about how you balanced your desire to have a family and kids with the demands of your professional pursuits?
Paul:	00:47:56	Well, that was one of the reasons I retired in 2014, because we had had a second child in 2012, and I was worried. I gave our first child a huge amount of attention, and I was worried I wouldn't be able to do the same for the second one. Now that there were two, how was I going to do this? I didn't realize that you can't give your second child a lot of attention because anything you do with the second child, the first one wants to come along as well. So I didn't get that then yet, but I did want to make sure I could spend a lot of time. And it's funny, when people get fired, they always say now they want to spend more time with their family. But that really was a big part of the

motivation. I wanted to spend time with family, but I also just wanted to work on other things.

00:48:43 And that was the trouble with YC. If you're a YC partner, you can have side projects, but if you're president, it takes up all your time and more. So the way I would combine it, but the thing is, YC was never nine to five. You didn't go to this office and stay there all day long and then come home and kiss your kids and then they go to bed. And so I was often at home. I was often at home, like hanging out, playing with the kids. It was well suited to that, well suited to having kids. And I want it to continue to be well suited for having kids. This is something like running a startup is not super compatible with having kids. I mean, people do it, but boy, they don't fit together nicely. I would like it if being a YC partner did fit together nicely with having kids.

Jessica: 00:49:33 Yeah.

Paul: 00:49:33 All right. What else you got on that Twitter thread?

Jessica: 00:49:35 Okay. Here's a good one. How do you keep a sane mind in the crazy world we live in? Keep writing smart essays and stay relevant with my skills at the same time.

Paul: 00:49:46 How do I keep a sane mind? Well, it's important to be married to someone sane. Yeah. That's a nice compliment. Seriously. I mean, it sounds like a strange compliment to describe someone as sane, but- I love it. The older you are, the more you realize that's actually a fairly unique quality. And so if you're married to someone, and as long as you don't both freak out at the same time, then there's always someone to calm the other one down, right? That's the advantage. So I recommend to everyone marry someone sane.

Jessica: 00:50:27 Here's a good one. I'd love to know what you've been surprised about in the last few years that goes against your essays. You've spoken about vibe coding being surprising, for example.

Paul: 00:50:39 Yeah. That's a good question. Well, everyone is surprised at the rate of progress in AI. I didn't think this would be happening in my lifetime. It didn't look in 2010 like we would have ... I mean, we've gotten to the point where you have to go back and read the definition of the Turing test. We're that close. So I mean, we have stuff that seems to me maybe you'd have to really try hard to make it fail the Turing test. At any given time, it's pretty much passing the Turing test with me. In fact, the weird thing is how normal this now seems. Because when I was a kid, I was very

interested in AI and I would dream about this future where you'd have this computer that would pass the touring test. You'd talk to it. It would be like talking to a person.

00:51:24 And now you ask ChatGPT some boring question and it gives you the answer and it's like, okay, it's so weird how we can adjust to everything. It just seems like not a big deal that we're passing the touring test all the time now. Has there been anything else that falsified? Well, I'm shocked at how young founders are. I don't like this trend at all. I don't like this weird thing where they want to go start a startup instead of going to college. I don't like that at all. So

Jessica: 00:51:53 When you say young, in this case, you mean like- 18. Yeah, like 17, 18 versus 22, 23. That's what you mean by

Paul: 00:52:01 Young. Right. I mean, Sam dropped out after two years, right? So Sam was 19 when he started the startup. Big difference between that and not even going to college. So that's a bit shocking. I sort of wish I could put the brakes on that one. Maybe I can. Maybe I can. I'm thinking of writing an essay, say it called Go to College that explains why it's a good idea to go to college. So what else has surprised me? AI, the youth of founders, I'm surprised at valuations. Demo day valuations are like $60 million now, right?

Jessica: 00:52:36 Oh my gosh. I don't think they're that high, but yeah, probably something- No,

Paul: 00:52:39 They are. They are. I've heard of multiple startups raising money at a 60 cap. That's 20 times the post-money valuation of Airbnb. 20 times. Yeah. Yeah. There's just so much money now, a demo day.

Jessica: 00:52:56 This is a related question. Which of your previous startup advice is different, if any, given AI?

Paul: 00:53:03 It hasn't changed things super much yet. I mean, it might get to the point where starting a startup is structurally different. At the moment, the main effect AI has had is it's a source of startup ideas. It's a source of things that founders work on. They work on some AI version of some product for some market, right? Or AI is the thing that gives them enough leverage to displace the incumbent. The world has changed enough because of AI. And we haven't gotten to the point yet where you can't start certain startups or you can't start startups because as soon as you start them, the model companies set some AI founders to duplicate

what you're doing. What were those German guys who would copy startups in the hope that you would buy them? Oh,

Jessica: 00:53:49 The Sam War

Paul: 00:53:50 Brothers? Samwors. Yeah, yeah, yeah. So now we have to worry about the Sams instead of the Samwors. Will the model companies start sending out armies of AIs to copy your startup? One day maybe, one day, that would be worrying. Sort of wonder what YC's model would be in that world. But here's something encouraging. You know what the best source of startup ideas is, your own needs, right? Think about this was Facebook, Google, Airbnb, all these companies were originally started to satisfy the founder's own needs. AIs don't have any needs. The AIs aren't desperate to pay the rent in their apartment and there's this conference and they think, okay, let's rent out some airbeds on our floor. That's right. AIs aren't desperate to know what the other kids in their year at Harvard are up to. So maybe however good AI gets at being intelligent, it won't replace all the human founders because it doesn't have the needs that lead to startup ideas.

00:55:13 Isn't that interesting?

Jessica: 00:55:15 I have a question. Obviously we live in England. We went back to America for a few weeks this summer in August, for the month of August basically. What was your impression of the startup world?

Paul: 00:55:31 Well, every time we go back, there's more AI. A larger percentage of the companies are doing some AI idea and they're using AI to write a larger percentage of their code. And OpenAI is bigger. Every time we go back, it's like the same bit more. The big surprise was something I already mentioned, how many super young founders there are. It seemed like I was constantly doing office hours that began with 15 minutes of, "Are you sure you wouldn't like to go back to college?" It's funny, people imagine YC is determined to force all these people to do startups so we can make money out of them. And here I am constantly trying to talk them into ditching the startup and going back to school.

Carolynn: 00:56:16 What do they answer you when you say, "Please go back to college, you should go back." Are they just like, "No, the time is now," because that's what I'm imagining.

Paul:	00:56:23	No, it varies. It varies from one extreme to the other. There's sometimes people who are like, "No, this is what I'm going to work on. " Like that 16-year-old guy, Rakov, right? And he was probably right. Yeah. He was a very unusual guy. He was just meant to do this, you could see. And then there would be other people I'd talked to and they were like, "Yeah, we were sort of wondering if we should go back to school."
Jessica:	00:56:51	I think none of them will go back to school unless their startup fails, Paul. I thought that all the time, I'm like talking to our older son being like he's going to convince them to go back to school and they're not going
Paul:	00:57:02	To. Some of them should. And I wish the ones who should would. There are people working on this B2B thing where you have to ... I mean, B2B, you have to be older, right? You have to be able to seem convincing. There were these women starting this startup who were 18 and they looked like they were 18. They're going to have a hard time walking in trying to convince some CIO to purchase seat licenses for their thing. Whereas if they just did the same idea in a couple years when they could seem older and more convincing, they could do the same thing and it would work better.
Jessica:	00:57:42	Unless someone else does it.
Paul:	00:57:44	Yeah. Yeah. That's
Jessica:	00:57:44	Always the risk. Other people
Paul:	00:57:46	Are always doing it. They could work on it in the meantime. They just don't have to try and be a company. And there's other ideas. Sometimes, I'll tell you, sometimes people would say, "Oh, I feel like if I don't do it now, it'll be too late. The AI revolution's happening now." And I said, "You know what? People said that two years ago. Were they right? Is it too late now?" They'd say, "Well, no, it's never too late." If it ever is too late because of the AI revolution, if it's really too late to ever start any kind of startup, we're all screwed. Think what that would be. Yeah,
Jessica:	00:58:20	I was going to say, we're in
Paul:	00:58:21	Trouble. You got to get a bunch of freeze-dried food and a shotgun and a bunker somewhere, nervous laughter.

Jessica:	00:58:30	I was going to say, ugh. And we cannot end on that. You know how I feel about ending on a really freaky note. How should we end, see Levy? How should we end on this? How should we end?
Paul:	00:58:42	We could talk about how fabulous YC is now. One reason it's interesting to talk about how well YC is doing is because YC is sort of like Reddit in the sense that Reddit had a long period where it wasn't really progressing because the founder, because Steve wasn't even there, but it was such a powerful model that it didn't die. It kept growing anyway. And YC was kind of like that. There was long periods where no one was paying that much attention to running it, right? And because it was so fundamentally strong, it survived. And so everybody thought they had Reddit pigeonholed. They thought, okay, it's like sort of a big deal, but not really. It's like a small sovereign state like Luxembourg or something in the sovereign state, but almost doesn't matter. Boy, all the Luxembourgers are going to be mad at me.
Carolynn:	00:59:34	Catching strays.
Paul:	00:59:36	All 300,000 of them.
Jessica:	00:59:38	We make it back to California and you in the kitchen all day long are having office hours with startups, much to my dismay when I'm trying to make lunch for the kids.
Paul:	00:59:51	Or when they see how messy our house is.
Jessica:	00:59:54	Let's not tell our listeners about that. That's my little secret. Secret. You Yes. So we come back. What makes you ... Because you have this infinite amount of enthusiasm and energy when it comes to advising startups. What do you get excited about by when we come back and you reengage with Y Combinator?
Paul:	01:00:16	Well, the reason I have so much energy is not because I'm benevolent and I have infinite desire to help them. I mean, I want to help them, but the thing that really makes me energetic is that I'm interested in their ideas. It's like, imagine if you were into puzzles of some kind and people came and supplied you with a constant stream of new puzzles. That's what it's like. They're like, "Here's what we're working on. How can we get users? What could this idea be? " They don't usually ask me that. I just tell them. And so that's why I have so much energy. That's why I always liked working on YC. That's the part I like. I

don't like arguing with people who are trying to maltreat the startups.

Jessica: 01:01:01 That's Gary's job now.

Paul: 01:01:04 Yeah. Yeah. Poor Gary. Only someone who's done it knows what it's like. But I love ... I don't think I would ever get bored of talking to founders about their ideas.

Jessica: 01:01:17 Yeah. And YC, it's so energizing. YC's doing so well. It's really fun.

Paul: 01:01:23 And there's a lot of startup mojo floating around YC that's not all that common in the English countryside.

Jessica: 01:01:32 Exactly.

Paul: 01:01:34 It seems excitingly exotic.

Jessica: 01:01:36 Well, I think this was a really fun conversation. We did some reminiscing, some predictions, some myth busting. There's something in it for everyone. Thank you for coming on again.

Paul: 01:01:50 It's always fun to talk to you.

Carolynn: 01:01:53 Like you do every day.

Jessica: 01:01:56 Yeah. I was going to say, I'll see you downstairs for supper. What are you cooking me?

Carolynn: 01:02:00 What

Paul: 01:02:01 Do you

Carolynn: 01:02:01 Want? Orange chicken. He's making much chicken. Orange

Jessica: 01:02:05 Juice chicken.

Carolynn: 01:02:06 Never.

Paul: 01:02:09 What do you want me to make?

Jessica: 01:02:13 I would like something very healthy. Carolyn, I know this is probably way too much detail for you, but we have parsnips from our garden. Nice. And weeks from our garden. Oh, that's nice. And so I was sort of thinking you can make something- I can make something with parsnips. ... with parsnips and leeks.

Yeah, sure. Let's get going. Okay. Sign off so you can get cooking. Bye, Carolyn. Bye guys. Bye. Bye.